If I Were You

The big idea

Douglas James's one-act play is a gripping thriller. A criminal (**the Intruder**) breaks into the lonely cottage of **Vincent Gerrard**, a playwright and actor, planning to kill him and take over his identity. Gerrard uses his **presence of mind** and acting skills to trap the criminal.

ONE-ACT PLAY

A short play with a single act, few characters, one setting and a quick climax. Here the setting is Gerrard's isolated cottage.

Summary

1. Gerrard is on the phone when an **Intruder with a revolver** enters. The Intruder discovers that Gerrard lives alone, few people visit him, and tradesmen leave goods at the door.
2. He reveals he is a **criminal** wanted for killing a policeman. He plans to **kill Gerrard and live as Gerrard**, since they look alike, to escape the police. He has studied Gerrard's habits.
3. Gerrard stays calm and even jokes with the Intruder. He asks about the Intruder's past to buy time.
4. Gerrard then invents a story: he says he himself is a **criminal** too, the police are after him, and his false beard, disguises and props prove he has been hiding. If the Intruder becomes Gerrard, the police will arrest **him** instead.
5. He tells the Intruder that his car is outside and there is a way out through the **garage**. He opens a cupboard, the Intruder walks in, and Gerrard **locks him inside**.

6. The armed criminal is trapped, and Gerrard, who never once lost his nerve, is safe: his imagination as a playwright has defeated a gun.

Characters

- **Gerrard**: witty, calm, intelligent, a quick thinker; turns his acting profession into a weapon. His humour unsettles the Intruder.
- **Intruder**: a small-time crook who thinks he is clever, but is boastful, impatient and gullible. He reveals his plan too early.

Themes

- **Presence of mind** in danger.
- **Wit defeats violence**.
- **Crime does not pay**.

GERRARD IS NOT A CRIMINAL

His claim of being wanted by the police is a lie to trick the Intruder. The props are for his theatre work.

LIKELY QUESTIONS

How did Gerrard outwit the Intruder? What was the Intruder's plan? Write a character sketch of Gerrard. Is Gerrard's humour a strength? Value points: calmness, wit, imagination, using the Intruder's own greed.

Quick recap

- Intruder planned to murder Gerrard and take his identity.
- Gerrard claimed to be a wanted criminal himself.
- He locked the Intruder in a cupboard: brain beats gun.

Practice questions

1. What was Gerrard's profession?
   (a) Police inspector (b) Doctor (c) Playwright and actor (d) Shopkeeper
2. What was the Intruder's plan?
   (a) To steal Gerrard's car (b) To kill Gerrard and take over his identity (c) To kidnap Gerrard for ransom (d) To hide in the cottage for a night
3. The Intruder was wanted by the police for
   (a) robbing a bank (b) escaping jail (c) forging money (d) killing a policeman
4. Which quality helped Gerrard most?
   (a) Physical strength (b) Presence of mind (c) His revolver (d) His wealth
5. What story did Gerrard invent to trap the Intruder?
   (a) That his wife was coming home (b) That he had a dog (c) That he too was a criminal hunted by the police (d) That the cottage was haunted
6. Where did Gerrard lock the Intruder?
   (a) In the garage (b) In the car (c) In the cellar (d) In a cupboard
7. Write a character sketch of Gerrard.
8. "Presence of mind can save us in a crisis." Discuss with reference to "If I Were You".

Answers: 1. c 2. b 3. d 4. b 5. c 6. d 7. see notes 8. see notes